Slide-a-Key: Teacher's Guide

Slide-a-Key is a free, printable paper transposer. Students cut it out and build it, then use it to move notes and chords from one key to another.

The reason to use it in class is that the tool makes the structure of transposition visible:

- The strips show that transposing is a fixed distance. Move the slider once, and every note shifts by the same number of boxes.
- The wheel shows that the twelve notes form a loop. Go far enough past B and you're back at C.

Students can find both patterns with their hands before anyone names them.

Why It Works in Class

- They make it. Cutting, folding and fastening turn a worksheet into an object. Students own a tool they built themselves in a way they never own a handout, and the first time the notes line up, it's their own tool that worked.
- They discover it. Hold back the explanation. When a student notices that every note moved two boxes, they've found the idea of an interval for themselves, and people remember what they find far longer than what they're told.
- They keep it. Let students write their name on the back, colour in the sharps, and take it home or keep it in an instrument case. A tool they reach for next week keeps teaching.

Choosing an Edition

Edition	Build time	Extra materials	Good for
Classic	About 5 minutes	None, though a ruler helps	A quick start; the slider stays lined up
Pocket	About 10 minutes	A brass paper fastener (split pin) for each student	A craft session; something to keep in a case or folder
Sleeve	About 20 minutes, plus drying time	A glue stick, and a craft knife for the window (adult help for younger students)	Something sturdy to keep; the slider can't fall out

All three teach the same ideas. Pick by the time and materials you have.

Materials

- One printed sheet per student, at 100% scale (not "fit to page")
- Scissors, or a craft knife and ruler for older students
- Pocket Edition only: one brass paper fastener per student, plus a pushpin to make the centre holes
- Sleeve Edition only: a glue stick, and a craft knife for cutting the window
- Optional: cardstock or heavier paper, for sturdier copies

A Sample Lesson (about 45 minutes)

1. Build it (5–20 minutes). Students follow the assembly steps printed on the sheet.
2. Try the example (5 minutes). Everyone moves C up to D, as in the printed example, and checks that the three main chords (I, IV and V), C, F and G, become D, G and A.
3. Explore (10–15 minutes). Work through some of the discovery questions below in pairs or as a class.
4. Use it (10 minutes). Transpose the chords of a song the class knows into a new key, then play or sing it.
5. Keep it (2 minutes). Students sign the back of their Slide-a-Key and take it with them.

Discovery Questions

Ask these before explaining anything. The answers are for you.

1. Count the boxes between C and D. Now count between F and G, and between G and A. What do you notice? They're all two boxes apart. Transposing moves every note by the same distance, called an interval. Each box is a semitone (half step), so two boxes make a whole step.

2. What happens if you slide the slider 12 boxes, or turn the wheel all the way round? You're back where you started, an octave higher. There are only twelve different note names, and they repeat.

3. Why do the strips have every note twice, when the wheel has each note only once? Because the notes form a loop. A strip needs the repeat so you don't run off the end; a circle loops back on its own.

4. Which boxes are shaded? Where have you seen that pattern before? The sharps and flats, which are the black keys on a piano. Just as on a piano, there are none between B and C, or between E and F.

5. Am becomes Bm. G7 becomes A7. What changes in a chord name, and what stays the same? Only the letter moves. The "m", the "7" and anything else after the letter stay as they are.

6. Move C up 5 boxes. Now, starting again, move C down 7 boxes. What do you get each time? F both times. Up five semitones and down seven reach the same note name, an octave apart, because 5 + 7 = 12. Older students can connect this to fourths and fifths.

Things to Watch For

- **Printing scale.** If the boxes don't line up, the sheet was probably printed with "fit to page." Reprint at 100%.
- **Spelling.** Slide-a-Key gives the right sound, not always the textbook name: in F♯ major, written music calls F "E♯". For chord charts and playing, the strips' names are fine.
- **Minor keys.** The yellow boxes show a major key's three main chords. For a song in a minor key, choose its relative major (C for a song in Am); every chord still transposes correctly.
- **Which part is which.** The fixed strip or outer ring is the key you're in now. The slider or inner disk is the key you're moving to.

Going Further

- **Transposing instruments.** Players of these instruments read music written in a different key from what sounds. To find the written note from the sounding (concert) note, move the slider up by:

Instrument	Move up by
B♭ trumpet, clarinet or tenor sax	2 boxes
E♭ alto or baritone sax	9 boxes
F horn	7 boxes

  Slide-a-Key gives note names only, not octaves. Some instruments, such as tenor and baritone sax, also read an octave higher than they sound, so the written note may sit in a different octave.

- **Guitar capo.** With a capo on fret N, move down N boxes to find the chord shapes to play. Going the other way, move up N boxes to find what a shape will sound like.
- **Guitar-friendly keys.** Move C up to G (7 boxes). C, Am, F and G become G, Em, C and D, and every one is an easy open chord. It's one reason so many guitar songs are in G.
- **Singing range.** Ask the class to find a key that suits their voices, then transpose the song into it.
- **Make the boxes bigger.** Have students draw their own strips or wheel from scratch. If they get the pattern of shaded boxes right, they understand the chromatic scale.

Sharing

Slide-a-Key is free for classroom use. You may print and photocopy as many copies as you need, and share the files with other teachers. Please don't sell it. See **`LICENSE.txt`** for details (CC BY-NC 4.0). More at www.slideakey.com.

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